

1950–1957

COUTURE GOWNS

Typically worn to balls and grand occasions by the wealthy elite, haute couture evening gowns were the ultimate expression of couture house art. They were bold and dramatic, and intended to draw attention to the wearer. Designers used the finest fabrics and the most intricate techniques to create them. Best known were French designers Christian Dior, Pierre Balmain, and Hubert de Givenchy; Spanish designer Cristóbal Balenciaga; and the American-based Charles James. While based on a runway model, a gown could be customized to the needs of a client for a specific event. The New Look silhouette emphasized the hourglass figure, with its narrow waist. Married women wore strapless gowns but young unmarried women wore gowns with straps or capped sleeves. Skirts were usually full, though the columnar sheath also grew popular.



1950

Fit and flare This Cristóbal Balenciaga gown shows the dramatic flare expected of haute couture eveningwear. Often inspired by his native Spain, his design draws on the bullfighting tradition with a sash over an intricately embroidered columnar skirt.



1955



Heavy brocade Hubert de Givenchy, who trained under Balenciaga, designed this evening dress. Using a heavy silk matelassé brocade in emerald green, Givenchy's design elements include a draped cowl neckline and a slightly dropped, sloping waistline.

18th-century inspiration Titled *Antonia* and designed by Pierre Balmain, this gown was inspired by 18th-century structure and trimmings. It includes heavy embroidery work, pearl beading, gold scrolls, green foliage, and red chiffon roses.



Taffeta gown Cuban-born American designer Luis Estevez created this gown. After training in Paris at the House of Patou, Estevez returned to the US to start his own label, which sold at department stores such as Bergdorf Goodman.